

Mexico City is the story of a hyper-planned canaled city that attempted to model itself after Europe while excluding the Colonia Populares. This has made Mexico City a city of contrasts and inequalities but also the motor of the Mexican economy. Today, Mexico City boasts a population of over 21 million people, has become increasingly cosmopolitan, but also increasingly unequal. Let's dive into its history.

START WITH THESE PICTURES. for every section add 2 or three of the images attached in this folder

1. Mexico-Tenochtitlan: the canaled city, early 1500s

Before it became Mexico City, the capital was Mexico-Tenochtitlan, a highly organized lake city built through canals, causeways, chinampas, and water infrastructure. Unlike Paris, whose urban identity was built around stone boulevards and the Seine, Tenochtitlan was an aquatic city whose order came from its relationship to the lake. This matters because Mexico City's later urban history is partly the story of trying to erase, drain, and build over that original water-based urbanism.



2. Spanish Conquest and colonial reconstruction, 1521 onward

After the Spanish conquest in 1521, the colonial city was built directly on top of Tenochtitlan, replacing the Indigenous urban system with a Spanish grid centered on the plaza, cathedral, and palace. The new city copied European ideas of order, hierarchy, and centralized power, but it was still physically dependent on the unstable lakebed below. From the beginning, Mexico City became a layered city: European in appearance, Indigenous and lacustrine in its foundations.

3. Paseo de la Reforma and the beginning of Europeanization, 1860s

Paseo de la Reforma was originally designed under Emperor Maximilian to connect the city center with Chapultepec Castle, and it was modeled on grand European boulevards such as the Champs-Élysées in Paris. This marked one of the clearest moments when Mexico City began using urban design to project European modernity and elite power. But unlike Paris, where Haussmann's transformation reorganized the city on a massive scale, Reforma created a selective corridor of modernization rather than a full urban restructuring.



4. Pax Porfiriana and the Parisian dream, 1880s–1910

During the Porfiriato, Mexico City's elites embraced Paris as the model of civilization, progress, and beauty. Wide avenues, monuments, mansions, parks, and European architectural styles turned parts of the city into a symbolic version of Paris in Latin America. However, this Parisian vision was concentrated in elite spaces like Reforma, Juárez, Roma, and later Condesa, while poorer neighborhoods remained excluded from the benefits of planning, infrastructure, and beautification. FOCUS THE MOST ON THIS!!! THIS IS WHERE THEY FOCUS ON CERTAIN NEIGHBORHOODS THAT ARE STILL FAMOUS TODAY LIKE POLANCO, ROMA, JUAREZ, LAS LOMAS (which are next to the Park and Reforma). Building on top of emperor s and ignoring others

5. Revolution, instability, and interrupted urban modernization, 1910–1940s

The Mexican Revolution disrupted the elite urban project of the Porfiriato and shifted national attention toward land, social justice, and political reconstruction. Mexico City continued to grow, but the dream of orderly Parisian modernization was interrupted by war, migration, and uneven state capacity. This period shows that the city was not simply “modernizing”; it was absorbing the social consequences of a country in conflict. MAKE THE MONUMENTO DE LA REVOLUCION THE EMBLEM OF THIS.

6. Colonias populares vs. Porfirian planned neighborhoods, 1940s–1950s

By the mid-20th century, Mexico City expanded rapidly as rural migrants arrived in search of work, housing, and opportunity. Planned Porfirian and post-Porfirian neighborhoods had parks, avenues, monuments, and better services, while many colonias populares grew through informal settlement and self-built housing. This is central to the thesis: the parts of the city that inherited European-style planning became richer and more desirable, while the areas left to grow informally were marked by infrastructural neglect.

7. The Metro and mass urban mobility, 1969 onward

The Metro, inaugurated in 1969, was one of the city’s most ambitious modern infrastructure projects and helped connect a rapidly expanding metropolis. Like Paris, Mexico City used mass transit to make the city legible and mobile, but the Metro also revealed inequality: it connected workers from peripheral neighborhoods to wealthier central districts. It did not erase urban inequality; it made the unequal city function.

8. The 1985 earthquake and the crisis of central planning

The 1985 earthquake exposed the fragility of Mexico City’s built environment, especially in central areas constructed on soft lakebed soil. Beyond physical destruction, the disaster revealed failures in government response, housing policy, and urban regulation. It also changed the political life of the city, strengthening civil society and making urban space a site of protest, reconstruction, and collective memory.

9. Neoliberal redevelopment, heritage, and gentrification, 1990s–2010s

As Mexico City became more global, neighborhoods like Roma, Condesa, Polanco, and Juárez were rebranded as cultural, historic, and cosmopolitan spaces. These areas benefited from the same qualities produced by earlier planning: walkable streets, parks, architecture, and proximity to Reforma and the historic center. But their success also produced displacement, showing how the Parisian-inspired neighborhoods became valuable precisely because they had been planned and beautified long before.

10. UTOPIÁS, inequality, and the current city

Today, projects like UTOPIÁS try to bring high-quality public space, culture, sports, and services to historically underserved areas, especially in Iztapalapa. In a way, they respond to the old urban imbalance: some neighborhoods received boulevards, monuments, and parks for over a century, while others were treated as peripheral or informal. The question for contemporary Mexico City is whether it can finally democratize planning, or whether beauty and infrastructure will remain concentrated in the neighborhoods that were once designed to look like Paris.

END THE TIMELINE WITH CONDESA.JPG VS IZTAPALA.JPG AND SAY HOW YOU CAN VISUALLY SEE THE DIFFERENCE IN GREEN + DENSITY + ACCESS